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Correct Answer

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Practice Exam - 1

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A 47 y/o woman with a HeartMate 3 LVAD presents to the clinic with a several-month history of signs and symptoms of heart failure including exertional and nocturnal dyspnea, elevated neck veins, and peripheral edema. Her pump parameters have been stable and there have been no alarms. A transthoracic echo is performed that demonstrates severe aortic insufficiency. Modifications of pump speed and lowering of blood pressure to a MAP of 75 mm Hg did not significantly improve the severity of the regurgitation, and she remained with NYHA class III-IV symptoms. Repeat right heart catheterization demonstrated an RA of 8 mm Hg, a PCWP of 24 mm Hg, and a cardiac index of 2.0 L/min/m². The patient is currently listed as a status 4 candidate for transplantation and has already used her elective 30 days at status 3. TAVR was deemed not an option due to anatomy of the aortic valve.

Based upon her clinical presentation, the following change in her listing status is warranted:

- A. Aortic insufficiency is not a qualifying criterion to increase the listing status and she should remain Status 4.
- ☒ B. The patient qualifies to upgrade to Status 3
- C. The patient qualifies to upgrade to Status 3 for another 30 days of elective time
- D. The patient qualifies to upgrade to Status 2 since she did not respond to changes in pump speed

Commentary

Correct Answer: B. The patient qualifies to upgrade to Status 3

Rationale: Aortic insufficiency is a recognized durable LVAD complication that qualifies an adult heart transplant candidate for Status 3 listing if the patient has persistent NYHA class III-IV symptoms despite a MAP <80 mm Hg and right heart catheterization demonstrates a PCWP >20 mm Hg. This patient has symptomatic severe aortic insufficiency despite blood pressure reduction and pump-speed adjustment; therefore, she qualifies for Status 3 due to an LVAD complication. Her prior use of elective Status 3 time does not preclude Status 3 listing for a qualifying LVAD complication.

Answer A: Incorrect. Aortic insufficiency is a qualifying LVAD complication for Status 3.

Answer C: Incorrect. This is not elective 30-day Status 3 time; it is Status 3 listing based on a qualifying LVAD complication.

Answer D: Incorrect. LVAD-associated aortic insufficiency qualifies for Status 3, not Status 2.

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